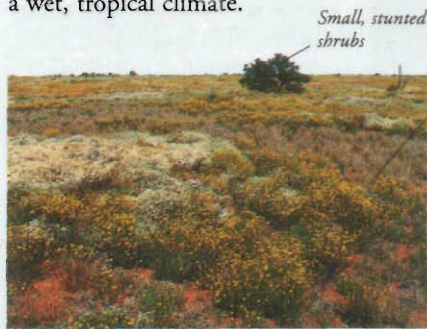
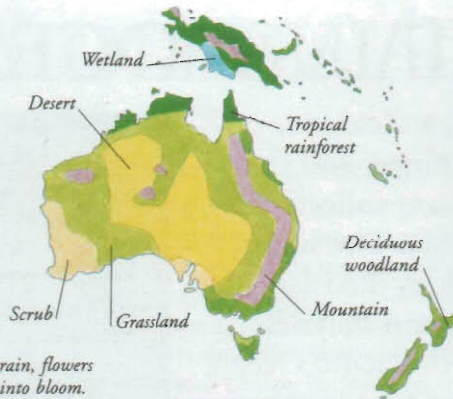


Climatic zones

With a wide range of landscapes and spanning such a vast area, Australasia and Oceania experience many different climates. Northern Australia and Papua New Guinea are always hot with wet and dry seasons, the east has hot summers and mild winters, and the centre is dry desert. New Zealand is mild and damp. The most westerly of the Pacific islands have a wet, tropical climate.

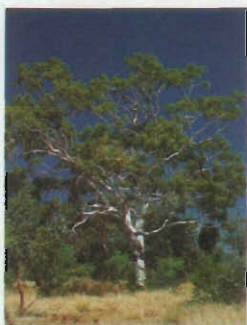


After rain, flowers burst into bloom.



Grassland

Australia contains vast areas of dry, open grassland, known as the "outback". The best grazing land for cattle and sheep is in Queensland and New South Wales. Scarce surface water is supplemented by underground water from artesian wells. Lush grassland covers the eastern side of New Zealand's South Island.



Eucalyptus woods

Many kinds of gum tree, also known as eucalyptus, grow in Australia. There is a species of gum tree for virtually every environment, from cold, damp mountain tops to hot, dry inland areas. Gum trees are evergreens, with leathery leaves.



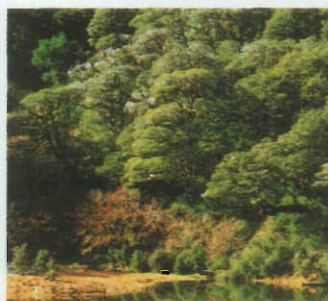
Narrow leaves hang down to avoid drying out in the hot sun.

Coastal climate

The coastal strip between Brisbane and Melbourne in southeast Australia is backed to the west by the peaks of the Great Dividing Range, including the Australian Alps. Warm breezes blow in from the Pacific Ocean, bringing rain to this green and fertile region. The long, sandy beaches and mild, pleasant climate make this the most populated region in Australia.



Byron Bay, New South Wales



Hot desert

The spectacular red Olgas rocks rise unexpectedly out of the arid flat expanse of Australia's scorching central desert. Situated near Uluru (Ayers Rock), this giant mass of boulders formed more than 570 million years ago and gradually eroded during the past 150 million years.



Deciduous woodland

The west coast of New Zealand's South Island is covered with deciduous woodland. Here, oak, beech, and hickory trees thrive in the mild, damp climate.

Beech forest in New Zealand's Fiordland National Park

People

The earliest inhabitants of Australasia were the Aboriginals of Australia, and the Polynesians and Melanesians from the Pacific islands. White Europeans began colonizing Australia and New Zealand in the late 1700s. Since the 1970s, Australia has allowed many other peoples to settle there, including Chinese, Cambodians, and Vietnamese.



Australian schoolchildren

Resources

Land is a major resource for Australia and New Zealand and is used extensively for grazing cattle and sheep, and for growing wheat. Australia is rich in minerals and leads the world in the production of bauxite (aluminium ore), diamonds, and lead ore. The main resources of the Pacific islands are fish and coconut products, such as copra, coir (rope), and matting.

